

TENSES

The Complete Concept Guide — read this before attempting RV03 Easy

Tenses answer one question: **when** did the action happen, and **how does it relate** to another point in time? Every trap in this topic comes from one of two sources — a time word that locks the tense (yesterday, since, by, ago), or a relationship between two actions (one before the other, one interrupting the other). Learn to spot the lock, and the answer chooses itself. This guide covers everything RV03 Easy and Medium will ask. RV03 Hard adds two traps from beyond these pages — that is deliberate, and each is fully explained on its review page. **Conditionals (if-sentences) are NOT covered here — they get their own Reviser, RV04.**

PART 1 · THE TENSE MAP

Tense	Skeleton	Its one job	Signal words
Simple present	V1 / V1+s	Habits, routines, facts	every day, always, usually
Present continuous	am/is/are + V-ing	Happening right now; temporary phases	now, look!, listen!, these days
Present perfect	has/have + V3	Past action tied to now	just, already, yet, since, for, ever
Present perfect cont.	has/have been + V-ing	Duration still running (or fresh traces)	since, for, all day, how long
Simple past	V2	Finished action, finished time	yesterday, ago, last week, in 2019
Past continuous	was/were + V-ing	Background action; interrupted action	while, when, as, at 8 pm yesterday
Past perfect	had + V3	The EARLIER of two past actions	by the time, before, after, hardly...when
Past perfect cont.	had been + V-ing	Duration running up to a past event	for an hour before, until
Simple future	will + V1	Prediction, promise, instant decision	tomorrow, I think, probably
Future continuous	will be + V-ing	In progress at a future moment	this time tomorrow, at 5 pm on Friday
Future perfect	will have + V3	Complete BEFORE a future deadline	by 2030, by the time, by then
Future perfect cont.	will have been + V-ing	Duration measured at a future point	for ten years by next June

PART 2 · PRESENT AND PAST — THE CORE

Rule 1 — Habits take the simple present

Routines, timetabled behaviour and general truths use V1: *She teaches on Tuesdays. The sun rises in the east.*

✗ *She is teaching on Tuesdays every week.*

✓ *She teaches on Tuesdays every week.*

Rule 2 — 'Right now' takes the present continuous

An action in progress at the moment of speaking: *Look!* / *Listen!* / *at the moment* / *these days* are the flags.

✗ Quiet — the baby sleeps.

✓ Quiet — the baby is sleeping.

Rule 3 — Stative verbs refuse the continuous

Verbs of mind and possession name states, not actions: **know, believe, understand, own, belong, love, hate, want, need, seem**. They stay in simple forms even for 'right now'.

✗ I am knowing the answer.

✓ I know the answer.

Rule 4 — Some verbs switch sides

Think, taste, smell, have, see, weigh, look are stative in one meaning and dynamic in another. Stative: *The soup tastes salty* (quality). Dynamic: *The chef is tasting the soup* (action). *I think you're right* (opinion) vs *I am thinking of moving* (considering).

GOLD TRAP — *This soup is tasting salty* is wrong — a quality cannot be 'in progress'. But *the chef is tasting the sauce* is perfect. Ask: is someone DOING the verb, or does the thing simply HAVE the quality?

Rule 5 — Finished time = simple past. No exceptions.

Yesterday, ago, last week/month/year, in 2019 close the time window. Once the window is closed, only V2 fits — never the present perfect.

✗ She has submitted the report yesterday.

✓ She submitted the report yesterday.

Rule 6 — Past continuous paints the background

A longer action forms the scene; a shorter simple-past action cuts into it: *I **was cooking** when the phone rang*. Pure scene-setting also runs continuous: *The sun was shining and the birds were singing when we set out*.

PART 3 · THE PERFECTS

Rule 7 — Present perfect = past action, present connection

Use has/have + V3 when the time is unfinished (*today, this week*), the result is visible now, or with **just / already / yet / ever / never**: *He has just left. Have you eaten yet?*

Rule 8 — Since takes a point; for takes a duration

since 2015, since Monday, since he left — a starting point. *for two hours, for a decade* — a length. Both ride with perfect tenses.

✗ We live here since 2015.

✓ We have lived here since 2015.

GOLD TRAP — The clause AFTER 'since' takes the **simple past** when it names a finished event: *She has worked here since she **left** college* — not *since she has left*. 'Since' licenses the perfect in the MAIN clause only.

Rule 9 — Gone vs been

Has gone to = departed, still away. *Has been to* = visited and returned. Repeated completed visits are always *been*.

✗ I have gone to Goa twice.

✓ I have been to Goa twice.

Rule 10 — Closed eras take the simple past

If the doer's lifetime or era is over, the present connection is broken — no present perfect.

✗ Tagore has composed hundreds of songs.

✓ Tagore composed hundreds of songs.

Rule 11 — Past perfect needs an anchor

Had + V3 marks the EARLIER of two past actions. With no second, later action in sight, it is unjustified — use the simple past.

✗ I had watched that film last Sunday.

✓ I watched that film last Sunday. / I had watched it before you recommended it.

Rule 12 — Perfect continuous = the running clock

Present: duration up to now, often with visible traces — *She has been studying for two hours (and still is)*. *Your eyes are red — have you been crying?* Past: duration up to a past event — *They had been waiting for an hour before the bus came*.

Rule 13 — 'By' + future = future perfect

By 2030 / by the time you arrive / by then set a deadline; the action completes before it: *By 2030 she will have completed her doctorate. By the time you receive this, I will have left*.

PART 4 · SEQUENCE OF TENSES AND REPORTED SPEECH

Rule 14 — Backshift: one step into the past

After a past reporting verb (said, told, asked), every tense steps back once: am→was · V2→had V3 · will→would · can→could · has V3→had V3. Time words shift too: today→that day, tomorrow→the next day, yesterday→the previous day, ago→before.

✗ He said he will come tomorrow.

✓ He said he would come the next day.

Rule 15 — Universal truths do not backshift

Permanent facts stay in the simple present regardless of the reporting verb: *The teacher said that water **boils** at 100°C. Galileo maintained that the earth **moves** around the sun.*

Rule 16 — Reported questions backshift the past too

'Where **were** you last night?' → He asked where I **had been** the previous night. The simple past steps back to the past perfect — students routinely forget this second step.

Rule 17 — Narrated sequences hold one tense

Actions listed in story order stay parallel: *She opened the envelope, read it twice, and placed it in the drawer*. Do not promote the last verb to past perfect — sequence order already does the work.

PART 5 · THE FUTURE AND TIME CLAUSES

Rule 18 — No 'will' inside a time clause

After **when, until, before, after, as soon as, once, by the time**, the future is written as simple present: *I will call you when I **reach** home. Until the results **arrive**, we wait.*

Rule 19 — ...unless 'when' is a question word

In indirect questions, 'when' is the thing being asked, not a time clause — so 'will' returns: *Please tell me when the train **will arrive**.* Test: can you replace the clause with 'the arrival time'? If yes, it is a question, and 'will' is correct.

GOLD TRAP — *Please wait here until the train will arrive* — WRONG (time clause). *Please tell me when the train will arrive* — RIGHT (indirect question). Same words, opposite verdicts. This exact contrast appears in exams.

Rule 20 — Future continuous: the in-progress future

Action in progress at a future moment: *This time tomorrow we **will be flying** over the Arabian Sea.* It also asks about someone's plans neutrally, without sounding like a request: *Will you be using the car tomorrow?*

PART 6 · WHEN THE RULES BEND

Five constructions where correct English appears to break Parts 1–5. Exams love these precisely because rule-bound students mark the right sentence wrong.

Rule B1 — The literary / historical present

Plots and historical narration run in the present: *In Act III, Hamlet **kills** Polonius. Napoleon **marches** on Moscow.* The past tense is not wrong here — but the present is fully correct and is the standard register for summarising plots.

Rule B2 — Timetable present

Fixed schedules of institutions take the simple present even for the future: *The Rajdhani **departs** at 6:10 tomorrow. The flight **leaves** at midnight tonight.*

Rule B3 — Arranged-future continuous

A personal arrangement already fixed takes the present continuous: *We **are meeting** the director on Monday.* Timetable present is for institutions; arranged continuous is for people.

Rule B4 — 'It is ages since I met him'

After *It is years/ages/a long time since...*, the since-clause names the LAST occurrence — a finished past event — so it takes the simple past, not the present perfect.

Rule B5 — 'This is the first time I have seen...'

The first/second/only time + present perfect, even though the sentence feels present: *This is the first time she **has flown** solo.* The structure counts occurrences up to now.

Rule B6 — Hardly / scarcely / no sooner — and never-inversion

These openers force inversion AND fix the tense pattern: past perfect in their clause, simple past after when/than — ***Hardly had we reached** the station **when** the train **left**. **No sooner had** the results **been declared** **than** the celebrations **began**.* Likewise, a negative opener inverts a perfect: *Never before **have I seen** such chaos.*

GOLD TRAP — Hardly pairs with **when**; no sooner pairs with **than**. Cross-wiring the pair (*no sooner...when*) is itself a tested error — but the tense pattern (had V3 ... V2) never changes.

ONE-PAGE REVISION TABLE

If you see...	...the tense is locked to	Example
every day / usually / always	Simple present	The museum opens at 9 daily.
Look! / Listen! / now	Present continuous	Someone is knocking.
know, own, believe, want...	Simple form only (stative)	I know the answer.
yesterday / ago / last year / in 2019	Simple past	She submitted it yesterday.
just / already / yet / ever	Present perfect	He has just left.
since + point, for + duration (main clause)	Present perfect (cont.)	We have lived here since 2015.
clause after 'since' (finished event)	Simple past	...since she left college.
repeated completed visits	have BEEN to (not gone)	I have been to Leh thrice.
a closed era / person no longer alive	Simple past	Tagore composed songs.
by the time / before + second past action	Past perfect for the earlier one	The movie had started.
duration up to a past event	Past perfect continuous	They had been waiting an hour.
by + future deadline	Future perfect	By 2030 she will have completed it.
this time tomorrow / at 5 pm on Friday	Future continuous	We will be flying.
when/until/as soon as (time clause)	Simple present for the future	...when I reach home.
tell me / know / wonder + when	'will' allowed (indirect question)	Tell me when it will arrive.
said/told/asked (reporting)	Backshift one step; truths stay present	He said he was tired. Water boils.
hardly...when / no sooner...than	had V3 (inverted) ... simple past	Hardly had we reached when it left.
this is the first time	Present perfect	...she has flown solo.
plot of a book/play/film	Literary present	Hamlet kills Polonius.
train/flight timetable	Simple present for future	The flight leaves at midnight.

SPOT CHECK — 10 SENTENCES

Mark each sentence Right or Wrong. Fix the wrong ones. Then check the key below. **Do not attempt RV03 Easy until you clear the readiness bar.**

1. I am knowing the answer to this question.
2. She has visited the workshop yesterday.
3. We have lived in this colony since 2018.
4. Hardly we had entered when the lights went out.
5. The teacher said that the earth revolved around the sun.
6. I will message you as soon as I reach the hostel.
7. It is years since I have met my school friends.
8. By the time the guests arrived, the cook had prepared everything.
9. I have gone to Udaipur twice with my family.
10. Please tell me when the seminar will begin.

KEY

1. **Wrong** — 'Know' is stative → I **know** the answer.
2. **Wrong** — 'Yesterday' is finished time → She **visited** the workshop yesterday.
3. **Right** — Since + point, main clause in present perfect.
4. **Wrong** — 'Hardly' forces inversion → Hardly **had we entered** when the lights went out.
5. **Wrong** — Universal truth stays present → the earth **revolves**.
6. **Right** — Time clause takes simple present for the future.
7. **Wrong** — Since-clause names the last occurrence → since I **met** my school friends.
8. **Right** — Earlier past action correctly in past perfect.
9. **Wrong** — Repeated completed visits → I have **been** to Udaipur twice.
10. **Right** — Indirect question, not a time clause — 'will' is correct.

READINESS RULE: 8 or more correct → start RV03 Easy now. 6–7 → re-read the rules you missed, then start. 5 or fewer → re-read the full guide once before attempting the test.

MOVEMENT RULE: Score **70% or above** on a test → advance to the next level. Score **below 50%** → return to this guide before retrying. In between → review every explanation on the results page, then retry the same level.

RV03 Hard adds two traps beyond this guide — a habit that irritates, and an assumption about the present. Meet them in the test; their review explanations will do the teaching. Next in the series: RV04 — Conditionals & the Subjunctive.